RECRUITGRID

THE RECRUITING PLAYBOOK

What to do, when to do it and what to say — for families figuring out college recruiting without a recruiting service.

15 chapters

recruitgrid.app

The Recruiting Playbook
First edition, 2026

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Every chapter is also published free at recruitgrid.app/resources.

This book describes a process. It is not legal, academic or financial advice, it does not promise any athlete a place or a scholarship, and it is not affiliated with the NCAA, the NAIA, the NJCAA or any college. Eligibility and contact rules differ by sport and division and change from year to year — confirm anything that affects your athlete on the governing body's own site.

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BEFORE YOU START

This book was put together by one parent who went through college recruiting and could not find the answers in one place. It is not a service, it does not contact coaches for you and it does not promise anybody a scholarship.

What it does is tell you what the steps are, in roughly the order they happen, and what each one is actually for. Every chapter also lives free at **recruitgrid.app/resources**, where it stays up to date.

One thing worth saying at the front: the rules about when coaches may contact you, and what you need academically, differ by sport and by division, and they change. Wherever that comes up, this book tells you what is generally true and points you at the NCAA's own pages for your situation. Do not take a date from a message board — including this one.

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PART 1

HOW RECRUITING ACTUALLY WORKS

1

HOW COLLEGE RECRUITING ACTUALLY WORKS, FROM THE COACH'S SIDE

> Coaches build a long list, contact it broadly, evaluate a much shorter list in person and on film, make offers to a handful, and sign the ones who say yes and are eligible. An athlete's job is to get onto the list early, make evaluation easy, and keep grades clean — because the last stage is decided by a transcript, not a highlight video.

Stage 1: The list

Long before anyone is recruited, a staff builds a list of names for each graduating class: players they've seen, players their contacts mention, names from questionnaires and camp rosters, and film that landed in the inbox. For most programs that list is hundreds of names long.

What gets you on it: a questionnaire submitted, an email with film, a camp at that school, or a high school or club coach who calls on your behalf. None of that means you're being recruited — it means you exist to them, which is the first requirement.

> Your job at this stage: be on more lists. Email the coaches yourself, submit questionnaires, and keep your film current.

Stage 2: First contact — and what it does and doesn't mean

Programs send a lot of mail: camp invitations, general letters, questionnaires, occasional social media follows. Most of it goes to the whole list. It is not an offer, and it usually isn't personal.

- A form letter or camp invite means you're in the database.

- A message that names where they saw you play, and what they liked, means a person is paying attention.
- A reply to something you sent is worth more than anything unsolicited.

Answer everything that comes from a school you would actually attend, within a day or two, from the athlete's own email. Ask a direct question back: are you evaluating my position in my class?

Stage 3: Evaluation

The list gets cut. Coaches watch film, come to games and events, run camps to see players in person, and start phone calls. They are judging more than skill: how you move without the ball, how you respond to a mistake, how you treat teammates, whether your body will hold up, and whether your grades work.

- Make evaluation easy: film that's current, clearly marked, and quick to open; a schedule they can plan around; honest measurements.
- Tell coaches where you'll be playing before tournaments and showcases.
- Expect quiet stretches. Coaches watch far more players than they speak to.

Stage 4: Offers

An offer can mean several different things, so ask plainly what is being offered.

- A verbal offer is a coach saying they want you, often with athletic aid attached. It is not binding on either side, and it can be withdrawn — coaches move, classes fill, staffs change.
- A written offer of athletics aid is the real document. It says what money you get and for how long.
- A roster spot or preferred walk-on spot means a place on the team without athletic aid. That can still be a great outcome, especially where

academic or need-based aid is strong.

Ask what the offer covers, for how long, what happens if you're injured or the coach leaves, and when they need an answer. Get the terms in writing before you decide.

Stage 5: Signing and eligibility

How signing works changed recently: the National Letter of Intent program ended in Division I in 2024, and athletes there now sign a written offer of athletics aid instead. Division II still uses the NLI. Ask each school exactly what you will sign, what it commits you to, and what it commits them to.

Then eligibility decides it. For Division I and II that means NCAA-approved core courses, a qualifying core-course GPA, and a final transcript with proof of graduation sent to the Eligibility Center; NAIA and junior colleges have their own standards. Every year, athletes lose spots here after the recruiting was already done.

What this means for how you spend your time

- Early years: grades and core courses, film, and getting on lists.
- Middle years: emails, questionnaires, camps at schools you'd attend, and answering fast when someone replies.
- Late: narrowing to programs that talk to you, asking hard questions about money and role, and keeping your transcript clean.
- Throughout: keep Division II, III, NAIA and junior college schools on your list. Most college athletes play outside Division I, and those coaches recruit later and longer.

Quick answers

How do college coaches build their recruiting lists?
From camps, questionnaires, film sent to them, events they attend, and coaches

they trust. For most programs the list starts at hundreds of names per class.

Is a verbal offer binding?
No. A verbal offer binds neither side and can be withdrawn — staff change, classes fill. The document that matters is a written offer of athletics aid, which states the money and the term.

What actually decides it at the end?
Eligibility. Core courses, a qualifying GPA and a final transcript decide whether recruiting turns into a roster spot, and athletes lose places here every year.

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YOUR RECRUITING TIMELINE, GRADE BY GRADE

> Freshman year: grades, the right classes, film and a first list of schools. Sophomore year: start emailing coaches and register with the NCAA Eligibility Center if Division I or II is possible. Junior year: the busiest stretch — updates, questionnaires, camps and visits. Senior year: narrow your list, apply, file the FAFSA and decide. Every level recruits on its own clock, so keep Division II, III, NAIA and junior college schools on your list the whole way.

Before high school

- Treat grades as part of your game — colleges see every high school grade, starting freshman year.
- Save game clips as you go. A folder of clips now makes a highlight video easy later.
- Play at the highest level you can. Club, travel and AAU teams are where you find out where you stand.

Freshman year

- Ask your counselor which classes count as NCAA core courses. Division I requires 16 of them; picking the right classes now is free, fixing it senior year is not.
- Put 10 schools on a list across three groups: a few dream schools, more where you'd realistically play, and a few sure things.
- Save film from every game.
- Fill out recruiting questionnaires for schools on your list — any age is fine, and it puts you in their system.

- In spring, look for a summer camp at a school on your list.

Sophomore year

- Start a free NCAA Eligibility Center profile if Division I or II is a possibility.
- Grow your list to about 20 schools across all levels.
- Email an introduction to the schools where you'd realistically play, with your film link. Coaches may not be allowed to reply personally yet, but they can read it.
- Send a short update with new film during your season.
- Plan two or three summer camps where schools on your list will be.

> June 15 after sophomore year is when coaches in most Division I and II sports can begin calling, texting and emailing you. Make sure every coach on your list has your current email, phone number and film before then. Some sports, like football, have later dates.

Junior year

- Fall: email every coach on your list a junior-year update — grades, schedule and newest film. Submit a questionnaire for every school that has one.
- Send your season schedule so coaches can come watch you play.
- Winter: keep the coaches who answer close with short updates every few weeks, and let replies tell you your level.
- Spring: plan summer camps and showcases where your schools will be, and upgrade to an NCAA Certification Account if Division I or II schools are interested — it's needed before an official visit or a scholarship offer from those divisions.
- Ask the coaches you talk to most for a call or a campus visit.

- Summer: tell coaches where you'll play before each event, and email every coach you met within a few days after.
- Ask your counselor to send your transcript through junior year to the Eligibility Center once grades post.

Senior year

- Fall: focus on the schools that are talking to you, and apply for admission — athletes still have to be admitted. Ask each coach about deadlines.
- File the FAFSA. It opens around October 1, and some aid is first come, first served.
- Register with the NAIA Eligibility Center if NAIA schools are on your list.
- November: many Division I and II programs sign their class when signing periods open. Ask each coach talking to you about their timeline.
- Keep emailing Division II, III, NAIA and junior college coaches — many recruit well into spring.
- Winter: send senior-season film. If a scholarship isn't there at a school you love, ask about walk-on spots.
- Spring: compare offers on total cost after aid, playing time and the degree you want. Check deposit deadlines — many are May 1.
- Send a courtesy note to every school you're not choosing. Coaches remember, and they move between schools.
- Summer: make sure your final transcript and proof of graduation reach the NCAA or NAIA Eligibility Center.

Still looking after graduation?

Junior college and a prep or post-graduate year are real routes. Junior college coaches can contact you at any time and often fill rosters late, and many four-year coaches recruit players after a year or two of development. Keep your film and profile current.

Quick answers

When should recruiting start?
Grades and core courses from the first day of ninth grade, because they decide eligibility later. Serious outreach usually begins in sophomore year, though there is no wrong time to start.

Is junior year too late to start?
No. Division II, Division III, NAIA and junior college coaches recruit later and keep recruiting through senior year, and many rosters are still being filled in the spring.

What matters most in senior year?
Applying to the schools talking to you, filing financial aid forms on time, keeping your transcript clean, and continuing to email coaches at levels that recruit late.

PART 2

WHERE YOU FIT

3

D1, D2, D3, NAIA OR JUCO: WHAT'S THE DIFFERENCE?

> Division I and II and the NAIA can offer athletic scholarships; Division III can't, but offers academic and need-based aid. Junior colleges are two-year schools where many athletes play, grow and then transfer. There are good players and good programs at every level — the right fit is where you'll play, afford it and earn a degree.

The levels at a glance

- NCAA Division I — 363 schools. The biggest athletic budgets and most scholarships, and the most competition for them. Most, but not all, Division I programs offer athletic scholarships.
- NCAA Division II — 305 schools. Athletic scholarships, usually partial, often combined with academic aid. Many D2 players could compete at lower D1 programs.
- NCAA Division III — 422 schools. No athletic scholarships, but many offer strong academic and need-based aid. Academics come first, and seasons are shorter.
- NAIA — about 250 schools in the U.S. and Canada. A separate association from the NCAA with its own rules; schools can offer athletic scholarships, full or partial.
- Junior college (JUCO) — two-year colleges. NJCAA Division I schools can offer full athletic scholarships, Division II partial ones covering costs like tuition and books, and Division III none. California community colleges, in their own association, don't offer athletic scholarships.

> School counts are from the NCAA's member directory for 2026–27 and the NAIA's own figure. Individual programs vary — a scholarship at one D2

> school may look nothing like another's.

"Full ride" is rarer than you think

Outside a few sports, most athletic scholarships are partial, and coaches split them across a roster. The NCAA itself notes that only a small percentage of high school athletes receive athletic scholarships.

What matters is the final cost after all aid. A Division III school with a large academic scholarship can cost less than a Division I school with a partial athletic one. Ask every school for the total cost after aid, in writing, and compare those numbers — not the word "scholarship."

Eligibility: who you register with

- Division I and II: register with the NCAA Eligibility Center. Recruits generally need an Academic and Athletics Certification account, which checks your core courses and grades.
- Division III: no NCAA certification is required to play, though schools set their own admission standards.
- NAIA: register with the NAIA Eligibility Center (PlayNAIA).
- Junior college: eligibility is generally handled through the college itself — no national certification before you enroll.

If Division I or II is a possibility, start your NCAA account early and plan your high school classes around the core courses it requires.

Why junior college isn't a step down

Junior college is a real route, not a consolation prize. Athletes choose it to get more playing time, to raise grades before a four-year school, to grow physically, or to save money on the first two years of a degree. Coaches at four-year schools recruit junior college players every year, and junior college coaches often recruit late — after many four-year rosters are set.

How to use all of this

- Build a list across levels. A good mix is a few "dream" schools, a larger group where you'd realistically play, and a few sure things.
- Let coaches tell you your level. Replies and interest from a level are better evidence than any ranking.
- Visit if you can, and ask current players how much they actually play and how the team balances school.
- Compare offers on total cost, playing time and the degree you want — not just the division name.

Quick answers

Which levels can offer athletic scholarships?
Division I, Division II, the NAIA and junior colleges can. Division III cannot offer athletic money at all, though academic and need-based aid at those schools is often substantial.

Is Division III worse than Division II?
Not as a playing experience — good Division III programs beat Division II teams regularly. The difference is how the money works and how much time the sport takes.

Who do you register with to be eligible?
Division I and II use the NCAA Eligibility Center, the NAIA has its own eligibility centre, and junior colleges set their own standards. Division III has no central registration.

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THE JUNIOR COLLEGE ROUTE: HOW IT WORKS AND WHEN IT MAKES SENSE

> Junior college lets an athlete play right away, improve, raise grades and cost less — then transfer to a four-year school. It works best when you choose a program that plays at a high level, develops players, and has a track record of sending athletes on. Plan the transfer from day one: credits and eligibility rules decide whether it works.

Why athletes choose junior college

- More playing time sooner, often against strong competition.
- A year or two to grow physically and improve before four-year coaches evaluate again.
- A chance to raise grades or complete requirements for four-year eligibility.
- Lower cost, sometimes with athletic aid.
- Many four-year coaches recruit junior college players who are ready to contribute right away.

Scholarships at junior colleges

It depends on the association and the division. In the NJCAA, Division I colleges can offer athletic scholarships, Division II aid is more limited, and Division III programs don't offer athletic scholarships. California community colleges do not offer athletic scholarships, though tuition is low. Ask each college exactly what it offers.

How junior college recruiting works

Junior college coaches can contact athletes at any time, and many recruit late — through spring and summer after senior year. Email them the same way you would a four-year coach: film, stats, grades and schedule. Many junior college programs also hold tryouts or camps.

Choosing a program

- Ask how many players have moved on to four-year programs in the last few years, and to which levels.
- Ask about academic support and how many players finish their associate degree.
- Look at housing, cost and how far from home — some junior colleges have no dorms.
- Visit if you can, and talk to current players.

Plan the transfer from day one

Transfer eligibility rules for moving from a two-year to a four-year school are specific and depend on the division, your high school academic record, and the credits and grades you earn. Meet with an academic advisor in your first semester, take courses that transfer, and ask the compliance office at the four-year schools you are interested in what they will require.

Quick answers

Is junior college a step down?
No. It is a way to play immediately, improve, raise a GPA and cost less, then transfer with tape and a transcript that prove it.

Do junior colleges offer scholarships?
Many do, at some levels covering tuition, books and sometimes housing. What is available varies by division and by state.

When do junior college coaches recruit?
Late, and for longer — junior college rosters are still being filled through spring

and summer, which makes them the list that is still live when others have closed.

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HOW MUCH ARE ATHLETIC SCHOLARSHIPS REALLY WORTH?

> Outside a few sports at the top of Division I, most athletic aid is partial — a share of the cost, not all of it. Division III schools offer no athletic scholarships but can offer academic and need-based aid. The number that matters is what a school will actually cost your family after all aid, so compare net cost, not the word "scholarship."

Full and partial scholarships

A full athletic scholarship covers tuition, fees, room, board and books. Many athletes receive a partial scholarship instead: a coach divides a limited budget across a roster, so an award might cover a quarter or half of the cost, and it can change from year to year.

Always ask exactly what an award covers, for how many years, and what happens to it if you are injured or the coach leaves. Get it in writing.

What changed in Division I in 2025

After the House settlement, the NCAA removed sport-specific scholarship limits in Division I from July 1, 2025. Schools in the settlement's conferences, and others that opted in, now have roster limits instead, and can choose to offer scholarships to any or all athletes on that roster.

That can mean more scholarships in some programs — but it is each school's choice, and roster spots are now limited. Ask each Division I program how it handles scholarships and roster spots in your sport.

Division II, NAIA and junior college

Division II and NAIA programs can offer athletic scholarships, and awards are commonly partial and combined with academic or need-based aid. Junior

college rules depend on the association and division — for example, NJCAA Division III programs and California community colleges do not offer athletic scholarships. Ask each college what it can offer.

Division III: no athletic scholarships, but not necessarily more expensive

Division III schools do not offer athletic scholarships. Many do offer merit scholarships and need-based grants, and some private schools with high sticker prices end up costing less than a public school's partial athletic offer. Strong grades widen these options.

How to compare what schools will really cost

- File the FAFSA every year from senior year. Many schools also use the CSS Profile.
- Use each college's Net Price Calculator — every college that takes federal aid is required to have one on its website.
- Look up average net price by family income on the College Scorecard.
- Compare offers on total cost after all aid, over four years — not on the size of the athletic award.
- Ask whether academic aid can be combined with athletic aid; policies differ by school and division.

Quick answers

Do most college athletes get a full ride?
No. Outside a handful of sports at the top of Division I, most athletic aid is partial, and many athletes combine it with academic and need-based money.

Can Division III schools offer athletic money?
No, but the academic and need-based aid can be large enough that a Division III school costs a family less than a partial scholarship elsewhere.

How should families compare offers?

On what you would actually pay after all aid, for all four years — not on the percentage of a scholarship. Ask each school for the net cost in writing.

PART 3

GETTING ON THEIR RADAR

6

RECRUITING QUESTIONNAIRES: WHAT THEY ARE AND WHY TO FILL THEM OUT

> A recruiting questionnaire is a form on a college's athletics website that puts your information into that program's recruiting database. It's free, takes a few minutes, and you can fill it out at any age. Do one for every school on your list, then email the coach to say you did.

What a questionnaire is

Most college athletic programs have a prospective student-athlete form — usually called a recruiting or prospect questionnaire — on their athletics website, often on the team's page. It asks for your contact details, school, graduation year, position, measurements, academics, schedule and coaches.

What you submit goes into the software that coaching staff use to track recruits. That's how a school can send you camp information or add you to a list for its sport and graduation year.

Why it's worth ten minutes

- It puts you in the program's own system, where coaches look when they're building a class.
- You can do it before coaches are allowed to contact you. An athlete filling out a questionnaire is not something the recruiting rules limit.
- It shows interest in that specific school — something a coach can see.
- Many programs send camp dates and news to the prospects in their database, so you hear about opportunities first.

> A questionnaire gets you on the radar; it doesn't replace an email. Coaches

> receive a lot of them, so pair each one with a short personal note.

Have this ready before you start

- An email address you check and a phone number.
- Your high school's name, address and your graduation year.
- Position, height, weight and any testing or key stats.
- GPA, test scores and intended major, if you know them.
- NCAA Eligibility Center ID (or NAIA ID), if you have one.
- High school and club coach names, emails and phone numbers.
- A film or recruiting profile link, and your upcoming schedule.
- A parent or guardian's contact information.

Keep it in one place and every form after the first takes a few minutes. Use exactly the same details on each one so schools can match you up.

Make sure it's the real form

Look for the questionnaire on the college's own athletics website, for your sport. Some links found online lead to third-party recruiting sites that ask you to create a profile or pay — that isn't the school's form. If a page asks for a credit card, it isn't a college questionnaire.

- Check that the form is for your sport, and for men's or women's where it matters. Some schools use one form for every sport with a dropdown to choose yours.
- Fill in every field you can. A half-empty form is easy to skip.
- Update it — or send the coach new information — when your grades, stats or schedule change.

After you submit

Email the coach who recruits your position the same day or the next. Keep it short:

AFTER-QUESTIONNAIRE EMAIL

Hi Coach Reyes,

I just filled out your recruiting questionnaire and wanted to introduce myself.

[Grad year] [position] · [height] · [High School], [City, State]
Film and profile: [link]

[One real reason your program interests me.]

I'd like to be on your list as I go through the process.

Thanks for your time,
[Your Name]

Then keep track of which schools you've done — it's easy to lose count across twenty schools, and to wonder later whether a school has your information.

Quick answers

Does filling out a questionnaire mean you are being recruited?
No. It puts your information in a program's database, which is where recruiting starts rather than proof of it. It is still worth doing, and it is free.

How many questionnaires should you fill out?
One for every school you would genuinely attend. Ten to twenty is a normal number, and it is worth keeping a record of which ones you have sent.

Should you use the athlete's email or a parent's?
The athlete's. Everything that follows — camp invitations, replies, newsletters — goes to whatever address is typed into the form.

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HOW TO EMAIL A COLLEGE COACH (WITH AN EXAMPLE)

> Keep it short. Put your grad year, position, height, school and a film link in the first two lines. Add one real reason you like their program. Send it from your own email, then follow up every three to four weeks with something new.

Before you write: pick the right coach

Start with the coach most likely to read it. At larger programs that is often an assistant or recruiting coordinator; at smaller schools the head coach handles recruiting too. The athletics website's staff directory lists every coach with an email address.

- Write to one coach at each school, not the whole staff.
- Use the coach's name — "Coach Reyes," never "Dear Coach."
- Send it from the athlete's own email account, one they actually check. Parents can help draft, but coaches want to hear from the player.

The subject line

A coach decides whether to open your email from the subject line alone, often on a phone. Make it the facts they sort by:

SUBJECT LINE EXAMPLES

2028 PG · 6'2" · Durango HS (Las Vegas, NV)
2028 PG · 6'2" | Coming to your October 10 camp
2028 PG · 6'2" | New film from this weekend

The first two lines do most of the work

Many coaches will read only the top of your email before deciding whether to watch film. So lead with who you are and the link — not a paragraph about how much you admire the program.

- Grad year, position, height, high school and city.
- A link to your film or recruiting profile. A link, not an attachment — attachments get filtered and take up space in their inbox.
- Your season stats and GPA on the next line, if you have them.

One personal line — or none

Add one sentence about why this program: a style of play that fits you, a major they offer, a game of theirs you watched. It is the line that shows you are not sending the same note to fifty schools.

> If you don't have a real reason yet, leave the line out. A blank says less than something generic like "I've always admired your program."

A sample email

EXAMPLE

Subject: 2028 PG · 6'2" · Durango HS (Las Vegas, NV)

Hi Coach Reyes,

2028 PG · 6'2" · Durango High School · Las Vegas, NV
Junior season: 14.2 ppg, 5.1 apg · 3.4 GPA
Film and profile: recruitgrid.app/your-name

I like how your guards push the pace in transition — that's where I play best.

I'd like to be on your list as I go through the process. I can send my fall league schedule if it helps to see me play in person.

Thanks for your time,
Your Name
(702) 555-0123

That is about 90 words. A coach can read it in the time it takes to decide whether to click the film — which is the whole point.

What to leave out

- A long life story. Save it for when a coach asks.
- Every award since middle school. Pick the one or two that matter.
- Attachments, including your transcript — offer to send it if they're interested.
- The same email to the whole list with only the name changed. Coaches can tell.

After you send it

No reply to a first email is normal, and it is not a no. Coaches are busy, and at many levels there are dates before which a coach isn't allowed to answer a recruit personally — though they can still read your email.

- Follow up every three to four weeks, and only when there is something new: fresh film, updated stats, your season schedule, or a camp you'll be at.
- Reply within a day or two when a coach does write back, even if the answer is "not right now."
- If a school hasn't answered after a few updates over several months, put more of your energy into the schools that are answering.

> Contact rules differ by sport and division and change over time. Before relying on a date, check the NCAA Eligibility Center or ask the school's

> compliance office.

Quick answers

How long should an email to a college coach be?
Short enough to read on a phone between practices — roughly 150 words. Grad year, position, height, school and a film link in the first two lines, one sentence about why that program, and a question at the end.

Should the parent or the athlete send the email?
The athlete, from their own address. Draft it together if that helps, but coaches want to recruit the player, and an email from a parent's account reads as the parent running the process.

What do you do if a coach doesn't reply?
Assume they are busy rather than uninterested, and follow up in two to three weeks with something new — a new highlight, a schedule, a season update. Two or three follow-ups over a season is normal, not pushy.

8

WHAT COLLEGE COACHES LOOK AT ON YOUR SOCIAL MEDIA

> Assume every coach recruiting you will look. Remove anything you wouldn't want a coach, teacher or employer to see, keep a clear photo and bio, and use your accounts to share film, stats, schedules and the teams you play for.

Why coaches look

Social media is a quick look at character: how you talk about teammates, coaches and opponents, how you handle losses, and what you post and share. Coaches are adding someone to a team and a campus, and many say what they find online has changed their interest in a recruit — in both directions.

What hurts

- Profanity, sexual content, drugs or alcohol, and photos with them in the background.
- Complaining about coaches, teammates, officials or teachers.
- Harassing or mocking anyone, including in comments and reposts.
- Anything illegal or dangerous — including "jokes."

> Reposts, likes and comments count. So does a private account that a friend screenshots.

What helps

- A clear photo and a bio with your sport, position, graduation year, school and club team.

- Short highlight clips and a link to your full highlight video.
- Schedules and tournament dates, so coaches know where to see you.
- Academic achievements, community service and team moments.
- Tagging your high school or club team, and following programs you are genuinely interested in.

A clean-up checklist

- Scroll back through at least two years of posts, stories highlights and tagged photos.
- Check likes, reposts and comments, not only your own posts.
- Change a handle that you wouldn't say out loud to a coach.
- Search your full name to see what comes up.
- Ask a coach or counselor to take a quick honest look.

Messages from coaches

Many coaches reach out through direct messages. Check your message requests folder, answer promptly and politely, and move the conversation to email or a call when it gets serious. Be careful with accounts that claim to be coaches but aren't from an official program — look for a verified school account or confirm through the athletics website.

Quick answers

Do college coaches really check social media?
Assume every coach recruiting you will look. It costs them two minutes, and it is the cheapest character reference available to them.

What on social media costs an athlete an offer?
Anything a coach would have to explain to an athletic director: fights, slurs, drink and drugs, running down teammates or officials, and arguing in comments.

What should an athlete post instead?

A clear photo, a bio with grad year, position, school and film link, and the ordinary things — workouts, team wins, academic news. It does not need to be a highlight reel.

PART 4

YOUR FILM

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HOW TO MAKE A HIGHLIGHT VIDEO COLLEGE COACHES ACTUALLY WATCH

> Keep it to two to four minutes, put your best five or six plays first, and make it obvious in every clip which player is you. Coaches often decide in the first 30 seconds whether to keep watching, so the opening matters more than the length. Have full game film ready for when a coach asks.

Start with who you are

Open with a simple title card for three to five seconds: name, graduation year, position, height, high school and club team, jersey number, and an email or phone number. No music intro, no slow-motion montage.

Then go straight to basketball, soccer, softball — whatever the sport. Every second before the first play is a second a coach might close the video.

The first 30 seconds decide it

- Put your five or six best plays first — not in the order they happened.
- Lead with what a coach at your position wants to see: a guard creating and finishing, a pitcher's velocity and command, a defender winning one-on-one.
- Show the whole play, from a second or two before your action to just after it. A coach wants to see how you read the situation, not only the finish.

Make it easy to find you

- Before each clip, mark yourself — a circle or arrow for a second, or freeze the first frame. Coaches will not guess which jersey is yours.

- Use your jersey number and color in the title card, so a coach can follow you if the marker is missed.
- Film from high and wide when you can, so the whole play is visible.

Length and what to leave out

- Two to four minutes is plenty. A longer video usually means weaker plays mixed in with strong ones.
- Skip loud music with lyrics — many coaches watch with the sound off, and some find it distracting.
- Leave out plays where you are not doing much, repeated clips of the same move, and anything from years ago unless it is your only film.
- Include a few plays that show more than scoring: defense, effort, communication, what you do off the ball.

Full game film

A highlight video gets a coach interested; full game film is how they evaluate. Keep two or three recent full games uploaded and ready, and when a coach asks for more, send them the same day.

Update your highlights during and after each season. New film is also the best reason to send a coach a short update email.

Where to put it

Upload to Hudl or YouTube (unlisted is fine), and put the link in the first lines of every email and on your recruiting profile. Test the link from a phone that isn't signed in to anything — a private video is a dead end for a coach.

Quick answers

How long should a highlight video be?
Two to four minutes. Coaches often decide within the first thirty seconds, so the

best five or six plays belong at the front rather than saved for the end.

Do coaches want full game film as well?
Yes, once they are interested. Highlights get you watched; full games show how you play when nothing is happening, which is what actually gets evaluated.

How do coaches know which player is you?
You tell them in every clip — an arrow, a circle or a spotlight at the start of the play, and a title card with your name, grad year, position and school.

PART 5

CAMPS AND VISITS

10

ARE PROSPECT CAMPS AND SHOWCASES WORTH IT?

> A camp is worth it when coaches from schools on your realistic list will be there to watch you, and you follow up afterward. A college's own prospect camp puts you in front of that school's staff. A showcase is only worth the money if it names the programs attending and they fit your level. An emailed invitation alone doesn't mean a school is recruiting you.

Prospect camp or showcase?

- A college prospect or elite camp is run by one school's coaching staff, usually on its campus. You're coached and watched by the people who decide that program's recruiting — the most direct exposure a camp can give you to a single school.
- A showcase is run by an events company, with coaches from several programs invited to attend. It can put you in front of many schools in one day — but only the schools that actually show up, and only if they recruit at your level.

> RecruitGrid only lists a showcase when its own page names the programs attending, so you can check the schools before you pay.

What an "invite" really means

NCAA rules generally require a college's camps to be open to anyone who registers, within limits like age, grade and space. Many schools email camp information to every prospect in their database, and camps help fund programs.

So an email inviting you to camp is a good sign you're in their system — not proof you're a priority. A coach who has actually watched you usually says so specifically: where they saw you, and what they liked.

When a camp is worth it

- The school is on your list, and at a level where you could realistically play.
- The coaches who recruit your position will be working it — not only current players or volunteers.
- The group is small enough to be seen. A limit on the number of campers is a good sign.
- The total cost — registration, travel, a hotel, time off — makes sense for what you'd get.
- You've already emailed the coach, so they know who you are before you walk in.

Ask before you pay

A short email to the coach a few weeks before can save you a wasted trip:

BEFORE-CAMP EMAIL

Hi Coach Reyes,

I'm a 2028 point guard at [High School] in [City, State] and I'm planning to attend your October 10 camp. My film and profile: [link]

Are you evaluating 2028 guards at this camp? I'd like to make sure it's a good fit before registering.

Thanks,
[Your Name]

A specific answer — "yes, we're looking at 2028 guards, come introduce yourself" — tells you far more than the camp flyer. No answer is useful information too.

- Read the refund policy before paying. Many events keep part of the fee or only give credit toward another event if you cancel.
- For a showcase, ask which coaches are confirmed, and whether any recruit your position and graduation year.

Make the day count

- Bring energy for the whole session. Coaches notice effort, communication and how you respond to coaching as much as highlights.
- Introduce yourself to the coach if the setting allows it, and thank them at the end.
- Write down one specific thing a coach said to you or a drill you did well — you'll use it in your follow-up.

Follow up within a few days

The follow-up is where most athletes let a good camp go to waste. Within two or three days, email the coach: thank them, mention one specific moment from the day, and include your film link and upcoming schedule.

If a coach says "stay in touch" or "come back next year," set a reminder for that date. Months go by fast, and the families who remember are the ones coaches hear from.

Quick answers

Does a camp invitation mean a college is recruiting you?
Usually not. Most invitations go to every name in a program's database. An invitation that mentions where they saw you play is a different thing entirely.

When is a prospect camp worth the money?

When coaches from schools on your realistic list will be there, the group is small enough to be seen, and you email the staff beforehand to say you are coming.

What should you do after a camp?

Email the coaches who ran your group within a few days, mention something specific from the day, and attach film. The follow-up is worth more than the camp.

11

WINTER RECRUITING CAMPS: WHICH ONES ARE WORTH IT

> Baseball and softball run real prospect camps from December through February, and football runs junior days in January and February. Winter camps are smaller than summer ones, so coaches see more of you. Email the coach before you register, and pick a school close enough to drive to that is already answering you.

Winter is a different season for every sport

There is no single answer to whether winter camps are worth it, because winter means something different depending on what your athlete plays.

- Baseball and softball: this is a real camp season. Colleges run prospect and ID camps indoors from December through February, and next year's roster is still being built.
- Football: junior days, mostly January and February. Campus visits for the class a staff is beginning to evaluate, usually cheap or free.
- Basketball: high school season is on and college staffs are coaching their own. Winter camps are scarce by design, and that is not a gap you need to fill.
- Volleyball, soccer and track: a few winter ID clinics exist, but the main camp season is summer. Indoor track athletes are competing, not camping.

The quiet advantage: winter camps are small

A summer camp at a well-known program can draw a crowd, and being one of a few hundred athletes on a field is not the same as being seen. The same school's December camp is usually a fraction of the size.

That changes what the day is. In a small session a coach has time to watch you through a whole drill, correct something and watch you do it again. That is evaluation. A big summer camp is often closer to a tryout you pay for.

> If you can only afford one camp this year, a small winter camp at a school that is already talking to you will usually do more than a large summer one at a school that is not.

Football junior days are the winter event to watch

Junior days land in January and February, after signing season and before spring practice, which is exactly when a staff turns its attention to the next class. Many are free, most are local to the school's region and they often include time with the coach who recruits your position.

Dates are published late — frequently in December and January, only a few weeks ahead. Checking the football page of the schools on your list every couple of weeks through the winter is worth more than any search you can run in October.

Email before you register, not after

This is the step that decides whether the money was worth spending, and it takes ten minutes. Two or three weeks before you register, write to the coach who recruits your position or region. Tell them you are planning to come, and include your film link, grad year and position.

SHORT NOTE BEFORE A WINTER CAMP

Coach Alvarez,

I'm planning to register for your December prospect camp. I'm a 2028 catcher at Silverado High School in Las Vegas, 5'11", and here's my film: [link]

I wanted to let you know I'll be there so you can look for me. Anything specific

you'd like to see from a catcher that day?

Thanks,
Jordan Reyes

Even with no reply, your name is in front of them before you arrive. With a reply, you have a coach expecting you and something to follow up about afterwards.

Pick for proximity, not prestige

Winter travel is expensive and the weather is a coin flip. A school two hours away that has been answering your emails is worth more than a flight to a big name that has not.

- Start with schools already on your list that have replied to something.
- Then schools within driving distance at the division your athlete realistically fits.
- Treat a camp at a program that has never responded as a long shot, and price it accordingly.
- Check what the day actually includes before paying — a session with position coaches is different from a group workout.

For an in-season sport, winter is about your games

If your athlete is in the middle of their season, the recruiting work in winter is not a camp. It is making sure the coaches on your list know when and where you play, and that there is current film from this season to watch.

When coaches may watch in person, and when they may contact you, differs by sport and by division, and the rules change. Check what applies to your athlete on the NCAA's own recruiting pages rather than taking a date from a message board.

Follow up within a few days

Write to the coach two or three days after the camp. Thank them, mention one specific thing from the day — a drill, something they corrected, a conversation — and include your film and your upcoming schedule.

A camp you attended and never followed up on is a weekend you paid for and threw away. The follow-up is the part that turns a day on a field into a coach who remembers your name in April.

Quick answers

Are winter prospect camps worth going to?
For baseball, softball and football, often yes — winter camps are smaller than summer ones, so a coach has time to actually watch you. For a sport in the middle of its high school season, like basketball, your games are the better use of a January weekend.

What is a football junior day?
A campus visit a college runs in January or February for players in the class they are starting to evaluate. It usually includes a facilities tour, time with position coaches and sometimes a workout. They are often free or close to it, which makes a nearby one hard to beat.

Should you go to a winter camp at a school that has never replied to you?
Email first and go second. A camp where the staff know your name is an audition; one where they do not is a weekend indoors with strangers. One short email two or three weeks before you register changes which of those you get.

PART 6

WHEN A COACH GETS IN TOUCH

12

WHEN CAN COLLEGE COACHES CONTACT YOU?

> You can email a college coach at any age. What the rules limit is when a coach can reach out to you. For most Division I and II sports, calls, texts and emails from coaches can start on June 15 after your sophomore year — some sports, like football, have their own dates. Division III, NAIA and junior college coaches have far fewer limits. Your sport's official NCAA recruiting calendar has the exact dates.

The rules are about coaches, not you

NCAA recruiting rules control when a college coach may call, text, message or meet with a prospect. They don't stop an athlete or a parent from reaching out. Emailing a coach as a freshman is allowed — and it's how many athletes get on a list early.

Before a coach is allowed to reply personally, they can usually still read your email, watch your film and, in many sports, send general materials like camp information or a recruiting questionnaire. So a camp flyer back instead of a personal answer isn't a brush-off. It may be all the coach is allowed to send yet.

Division by division

- Division I: for most sports, coaches can begin calling, texting, emailing and messaging on June 15 after sophomore year. Football, basketball and a handful of other sports have their own calendars, and some dates are later.
- Division II: communication generally opens June 15 after sophomore year as well. The NCAA publishes one Division II recruiting guide and calendar covering all sports.

- Division III: far fewer restrictions on when coaches can contact you. D3 schools don't offer athletics scholarships, but many offer academic and need-based aid.
- NAIA: coaches generally aren't limited on when they can reach out.
- Junior college (NJCAA and others): contact is generally open as well — which is one reason junior college coaches often recruit late in the process.

> Rules change, and conferences and schools can add their own. Treat the dates above as a starting point and confirm yours on your sport's official calendar or with the school's athletics compliance office.

Contact, evaluation, quiet and dead periods

Once communication is allowed, recruiting calendars divide the year into periods that control in-person recruiting. In the NCAA's own terms:

- Contact period: a coach may meet you or your parents face to face, watch you compete, visit your high school, and write or call.
- Evaluation period: a coach may watch you compete and visit your high school, and write or call — but no off-campus face-to-face contact.
- Quiet period: no off-campus face-to-face contact, no watching you compete or visiting your school. Coaches may still write or call.
- Dead period: no face-to-face contact at all, and no watching you compete. Coaches may still write or call.

This is why a coach may be at your tournament but only nod hello. During an evaluation period they're allowed to watch you, not to talk with you there.

Signing dates for 2026–27

These are the first dates a high school senior can sign a Division I or II athletics aid agreement this year, as published by the NCAA:

- Division I basketball: early period November 11–18, 2026; regular period opens April 14, 2027.
- Division I football: early period December 2–4, 2026; regular period opens February 3, 2027.
- All other Division I and II sports: November 11, 2026.

Once you sign, coaches at other schools that offer athletics scholarships have to stop recruiting you. A verbal commitment, by contrast, isn't binding on you or the school.

What to do at each stage

- Freshman and sophomore year: email coaches at schools you're interested in, fill out their questionnaires, go to camps, and keep your grades up. Don't read silence as a no.
- June 15 after sophomore year: make sure every coach on your list has your current email, phone number and film — this is when many can start writing back.
- Junior year: the busiest stretch for most Division I and II recruiting. Keep coaches updated with your schedule and new film, and answer anyone who writes within a day or two.
- Any time: register with the NCAA Eligibility Center if Division I or II is a possibility. The NCAA notes that coaches can see whether you've registered.

Quick answers

Can you email a college coach as a freshman?
Yes. The rules restrict when coaches may contact athletes, not when athletes may contact coaches. An email sent at any age is allowed — a coach may simply not be permitted to reply yet.

Why would a coach not reply to a younger athlete?
In several Division I and II sports, staff cannot respond personally until a set date, usually in the athlete's sophomore or junior year. Silence at that stage is usually the calendar, not a verdict.

Do Division III and NAIA have the same contact rules?
No. Division III and the NAIA are far less restricted, which is why younger athletes often hear back from those coaches first.

13

WHAT TO SAY WHEN A COLLEGE COACH CALLS — AND WHAT TO ASK

> Answer yourself, be ready to talk about your season and your goals, and ask real questions — coaches expect them, and they tell you whether a program fits. Keep a short list of questions on your phone, take notes after every call, and send a thank-you the same day.

Before the phone rings

- Save the coaches on your list in your contacts, so you recognize the call and answer it.
- Know a few things about each program: last season's record, the conference, the head coach's name, and a major you might study there.
- Have your season stats, grades and upcoming schedule where you can see them.
- The athlete takes the call, not a parent. Coaches want to hear how you communicate.

On the call

- Find a quiet place, say thank you, and let the coach lead at first.
- When asked about yourself, be specific: your position, what you do well, what you are working on, and your goals in college — on the court or field and in the classroom.
- It's fine to say "I don't know yet" about a major or a decision date. It's not fine to sound uninterested.

Questions to ask about the program

- How do you see me fitting into your program — what position and role?

- How many players at my position are you recruiting in my class?
- What does a typical week look like in season and out of season?
- How do players earn playing time as freshmen?
- What is your style of play, and why do you think my game fits it?

Questions about school, life and cost

- How do athletes on the team balance classes with practice and travel? Are there majors that don't work with the schedule?
- What academic support is there for athletes?
- Is there athletic aid available for my position, and how do academic and need-based aid work alongside it at your school?
- What should I do next — a visit, a camp, a questionnaire, more film?

> Asking about money is normal and expected. Coaches would rather you ask than be surprised later.

After the call

- Write down what you learned while it's fresh — names, what they asked for, any dates.
- Send a short thank-you email the same day, mentioning one thing from the conversation.
- Do what they asked for, and set a reminder if they said to follow up at a certain time.

Quick answers

Should the athlete or the parent answer the call?
The athlete. A parent can be in the room and can join at the end, but a coach is calling to hear how the player talks, thinks and answers.

What questions should you ask a college coach?

Ask about your role and the players they are recruiting at your position, what a normal week looks like in and out of season, and what the school costs after aid.

What happens after the call?

Send a short thank-you the same day, answer anything you promised to send, and write down what was said — in three months those details are what make the next conversation easy.

PART 7

STAYING ELIGIBLE

14

WHAT CLASSES DO YOU NEED? NCAA CORE COURSES EXPLAINED

> For Division I and II you need 16 NCAA-approved core courses in set subjects, a core-course GPA of at least 2.3 (D1) or 2.2 (D2), and a final transcript with proof of graduation. Division I adds the 10/7 rule: 10 of the 16 — including 7 in English, math or science — must be finished before senior year. Not every class at your school counts, so check your school's NCAA-approved course list with your counselor early.

What a "core course" is

A core course is an academic class your high school has had approved by the NCAA — the courses that count toward eligibility. Every high school has its own NCAA-approved course list, and a class that is not on it does not count, whatever grade you get.

Your NCAA core-course GPA is calculated only from those approved courses. It is not the GPA on your report card, and it can come out higher or lower than the one your school shows.

> Ask your counselor for your school's NCAA-approved course list before you pick next year's classes. Fixing a schedule as a freshman or sophomore is easy; finding a gap as a senior often isn't.

Division I: 16 core courses

- English: 4 years
- Math (Algebra I or higher): 3 years
- Science: 2 years
- Extra English, math or science: 1 year

- Social science: 2 years
- Extra core courses (world language, comparative religion or philosophy among them): 4 years

Division I also requires a core-course GPA of at least 2.3, a final transcript with proof of graduation, and certification by the NCAA Eligibility Center before you can practice, compete or receive athletics aid as a freshman.

The 10/7 rule (Division I only)

Timing counts as much as the total. Ten of your 16 core courses — seven of them in English, math or science — must be complete before the start of your seventh semester, which is the start of senior year.

In practice the work has to be spread across freshman, sophomore and junior years. You cannot save core courses for senior year and catch up.

> Division I students who graduate on time may be able to use one additional NCAA-approved core course within a year after graduation, before enrolling full time in college.

Division II: 16 core courses, different spread

- English: 3 years
- Math (Algebra I or higher): 2 years
- Science: 2 years
- Extra English, math or science: 3 years
- Social science: 2 years
- Extra core courses (world language, comparative religion or philosophy among them): 4 years

Division II requires a core-course GPA of at least 2.2 and a final transcript with proof of graduation. There is no 10/7 rule in Division II.

Division III, NAIA and junior college

- Division III: schools set their own admissions and academic standards — there is no NCAA core-course requirement. Register with the Eligibility Center for an NCAA ID (a free Profile page) and ask each school what it expects.
- NAIA: an entering freshman is eligible with a final high school GPA of at least 2.3. Below that, you need two of these three: a 2.0 GPA, graduating in the top half of your class, or an 18 ACT / 970 SAT. Register at the NAIA Eligibility Center.
- Junior college: standards are set by the NJCAA or your state's system and by the college itself, and are generally the most flexible. Ask the college directly — and if you plan to transfer to a four-year school later, ask what credits will transfer before you enroll.

What to do, by year

- Freshman year: get your school's NCAA-approved course list and plan four years of classes against it with your counselor.
- Sophomore year: create an NCAA Eligibility Center account, and check that you're on pace for the 10/7 rule if Division I is possible.
- Junior year: recheck the count before you choose senior classes, and ask your counselor to upload your transcript once junior grades post.
- Senior year: keep your grades up — eligibility is decided on the final transcript — and have your counselor send that transcript with proof of graduation.

If a course was not approved, or a grade pulls the core GPA below the line, there are usually options — but only with time left to use them. That is the whole reason to check early.

Where these numbers come from

Everything above is taken from the NCAA Eligibility Center's own Division I, II and III pages and the NAIA's freshman eligibility rules, checked on September 15, 2026. Standards change, and rules differ for international students. Confirm with the official pages below and your counselor before making a decision.

Quick answers

How many NCAA core courses do you need?
Sixteen for both Division I and Division II, in set subject areas, with a qualifying core-course GPA and a final transcript sent to the Eligibility Center.

What is the 10/7 rule?
A Division I requirement that ten of the sixteen core courses, including seven in English, maths and science, are finished before the start of senior year. Grades in those ten are locked once the seventh semester begins.

Do Division III and NAIA use core courses?
No. Division III sets admission and eligibility standards school by school, and the NAIA has its own requirements through its eligibility centre.

PART 8

FOR PARENTS

15

THE PARENT'S ROLE IN COLLEGE RECRUITING: WHAT HELPS AND WHAT HURTS

> Coaches want to recruit the athlete, not the parent. The biggest help a parent gives is behind the scenes — organizing, keeping deadlines, handling the money questions and asking honest questions at home — while the athlete does the emailing, the calls and the talking.

What coaches notice

College coaches recruit a person they will coach for four years. How an athlete communicates — and how the family behaves — is part of what they evaluate. Coaches watch sidelines and stands at games and camps, and many say a difficult parent can end their interest in a player they otherwise like.

Where parents help most

- Organizing: a shared list of schools, deadlines, camp dates and who has been contacted.
- Keeping momentum: a weekly check-in on what was sent, who replied and what is due.
- Honest conversations at home about level, distance, cost and what matters beyond sports.
- Money: understanding financial aid, the FAFSA and what each school will really cost.
- Visits: coming along, asking your own questions, and watching how the program treats families.
- Film: helping record games and keeping the video organized.

What to let the athlete do

- Send the emails, from the athlete's own address. Draft them together if that helps.
- Take coach calls and answer texts.
- Talk first during visits and meetings. Parents can add questions after.
- Make the final decision, with your guidance.

Mistakes that cost opportunities

- Writing to coaches as the parent, or answering questions meant for the athlete.
- Criticizing coaches, officials or teammates in the stands or on social media.
- Overselling ability. Coaches evaluate for themselves; exaggeration hurts trust.
- Aiming only at dream schools. A list with realistic and sure-thing schools keeps options open.
- Leaving money questions until an offer arrives.

Questions worth asking coaches as a parent

- What does support for athletes look like — academics, health, time management?
- What is the total cost of attendance, and what aid is typical for athletes in this program?
- How do you communicate with families, and who do we contact with questions?

Quick answers

What should a parent do in the recruiting process?
The organising — deadlines, film logistics, travel, money questions and keeping

track of who has been contacted — while the athlete does the talking and the emailing.

Do coaches mind talking to parents?
Not at all, about the right things: cost, academics, safety, travel. What costs opportunities is a parent answering questions asked of the athlete.

What is the most common parent mistake?
Sending the emails themselves. Coaches notice immediately, and it raises the one question they cannot ask out loud — whether the athlete wants this.

WORKSHEETS

FILL THESE IN

YOUR TARGET LIST

> Two dream schools, five targets, three safeties. Ten is the number most families can actually keep up with, and it is what the free plan holds.

SCHOOL	DIV	COACH	EMAILED	REPLIED
DREAM — REACH, GO ANYWAY				
TARGET — REALISTIC FIT				
SAFETY — WOULD TAKE YOU TODAY				

CAMP BUDGET

> Fill this in before you register, not after. A camp at a school that has never replied is a long shot — price it like one.

CAMP / SCHOOL	DATE	FEE	TRAVEL	TOTAL	HAVE THEY REPLIED?

QUESTIONS TO ASK ON A COACH CALL

> Write your answers down during the call. By January you will not remember which school said what.

QUESTION	WHAT THEY SAID
Where do I fit on your roster, and in which class?	
What does a realistic aid package look like for someone in my position?	
What does a normal week look like in season?	
How many in my position are you recruiting?	
What happens to my spot if I get injured?	
What do you need from me next, and by when?	

COACH CONTACT LOG

> One line per conversation. The families who end up with options are almost always the ones who kept notes.

DATE	SCHOOL / COACH	WHAT WAS SAID	NEXT STEP	BY WHEN

ONE PLACE TO KEEP IT ALL

Knowing the steps is the hard part. Doing them for twenty schools, over two years, without losing track is the other hard part.

RecruitGrid keeps your coach list, your emails, your film and your camps in one place, and tells you who has gone quiet. Free to start, no card.

recruitgrid.app